

## ESSENTIAL

# Short-Stay Visa (Type C) Master Guide

The complete walkthrough - consulates, insurance, the 90/180 rule, and FAQs

**VERIFY BEFORE YOU APPLY**

Fees, forms, and processing times change without notice. This guide reflects publicly documented procedures as commonly published; treat every dollar figure, form number, and timeline here as a starting point, and confirm the current version on the official government site before you submit anything or pay any fee.

## What the Schengen Short-Stay Visa is - and isn't

A Type C visa lets you travel across the 29 Schengen area states for tourism, visiting family or friends, or short business activities, for up to 90 days within any 180-day period. It's a uniform visa - decided under the shared EU Visa Code, but issued by the individual member state responsible for your application, not a supranational EU authority. Note that "Schengen" and "EU" aren't the same thing: some EU members (e.g. Ireland) aren't in Schengen, and some Schengen states (e.g. Norway, Iceland, Switzerland, Liechtenstein) aren't EU members. It does not permit employment, and it doesn't cover stays longer than 90/180 days - those need a national long-stay (Type D) visa from the specific country instead.

## The process end to end

| Step                                  | What happens                                                                                                                                                                  |
|---------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1. Identify the responsible consulate | Based on your main destination or first point of entry - see the Application Walkthrough.                                                                                     |
| 2. Buy travel medical insurance       | Meeting the mandatory minimum coverage, for your whole trip and the whole Schengen area.                                                                                      |
| 3. Complete the application           | The standard EU-wide Schengen visa application form, at the responsible consulate or visa application centre.                                                                 |
| 4. Pay the fee and give biometrics    | Unless reusing biometrics from a Schengen application within the last 59 months.                                                                                              |
| 5. Submit documents                   | Insurance, accommodation, travel, and financial evidence - see the Document Checklist.                                                                                        |
| 6. Decision                           | Standard processing is commonly around 15 calendar days, though this can extend up to 30 or 60 days in specific cases - check current timelines with your specific consulate. |

| Step             | What happens                                                                                                                      |
|------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 7. Get your visa | If approved, a visa sticker (vignette) is affixed in your passport, stating your validity period and permitted number of entries. |

## Multiple-entry visas and the “cascade” principle

First-time Schengen applicants are often issued a single- or double-entry visa valid just for the requested trip. The Visa Code sets out a “cascade” principle: applicants with a good compliance history from previous visas (used lawfully, no overstays) can progressively be issued multiple-entry visas valid for longer periods - potentially up to 5 years - at the consulate's discretion. This isn't automatic; it builds over successive lawful applications.

## The 90/180-day rule

Your permitted stay is 90 days within any rolling 180-day period across the whole Schengen area combined - not per country. Time spent in one Schengen country counts against your total even if you then travel to another. Overstaying, even briefly, is recorded and can affect future applications.

## Frequently asked questions

### Can I work on a Schengen tourist visa?

No - a Type C visa doesn't permit employment. Limited business activities (meetings, negotiations, conferences) are generally permitted without amounting to work, similar to other countries' visitor routes, but this isn't a work authorisation.

### Do I need separate insurance for each country I visit?

No - one policy meeting the minimum coverage, valid across the whole Schengen area for your full trip, is sufficient.

### What if I'm refused?

See the Refusal Decision Guide (Premium tier) for how the appeal process works and what actually helps in a reapplication.